1844–1926

Mary Cassatt beyond the mother-and-child picture

Children, travellers and theatre-goers do not always look where a portrait expects them to.



The little girl in the blue armchair has expensive clothes and an entirely informal way of sitting. Cassatt allows those things to coexist. Elsewhere in this selection, a child looks away from an affectionate adult, a woman seals a letter without revealing its contents, and theatre-goers direct their attention beyond the frame.

These pictures give ordinary activity a structure without finishing the story on the figures' behalf. Who looks, who works, and who supports someone else's weight are useful questions to carry through them. The prints sharpen those relationships by reducing shading and giving more work to contour and pattern. Their apparent simplicity rests on carefully chosen positions.

Twenty paintings and print designs, each represented by a particular object. The selection is editorial; it is not a complete catalogue or a museum ranking.

Explore this selection in Artline

Open these twenty works alongside books and events from their period. The lifespan view includes Mary Cassatt, Berthe Morisot, Edgar Degas and Claude Monet. These comparisons provide historical context, not claims of direct influence.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/mary-cassatt

The selection · 20

1. Little Girl in a Blue Armchair
   Mary Cassatt · 1878
2. The Loge
   Mary Cassatt · c. 1878-1880
3. Woman with a Fan
   Mary Cassatt · c. 1878/1879
4. The Cup of Tea
   Mary Cassatt · c. 1880–1881
5. Young Girl at a Window
   Mary Cassatt · c. 1883-1884
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17. The Boating Party
    Mary Cassatt · 1893/1894
18. The Child's Bath
    Mary Cassatt · 1893
19. Breakfast in Bed
    Mary Cassatt · 1897
20. Woman with a Sunflower
    Mary Cassatt · c. 1905

01 / 20

Little Girl in a Blue Armchair

Mary Cassatt

1878 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

The room offers more seating than the child needs, but none of it persuades her into a formal pose. Her sprawling limbs interrupt the upholstered curves around her; the dog has settled into another chair. The contrast with her dressed-up appearance is enough to animate the picture. Whether she is bored, tired or simply comfortable remains open.

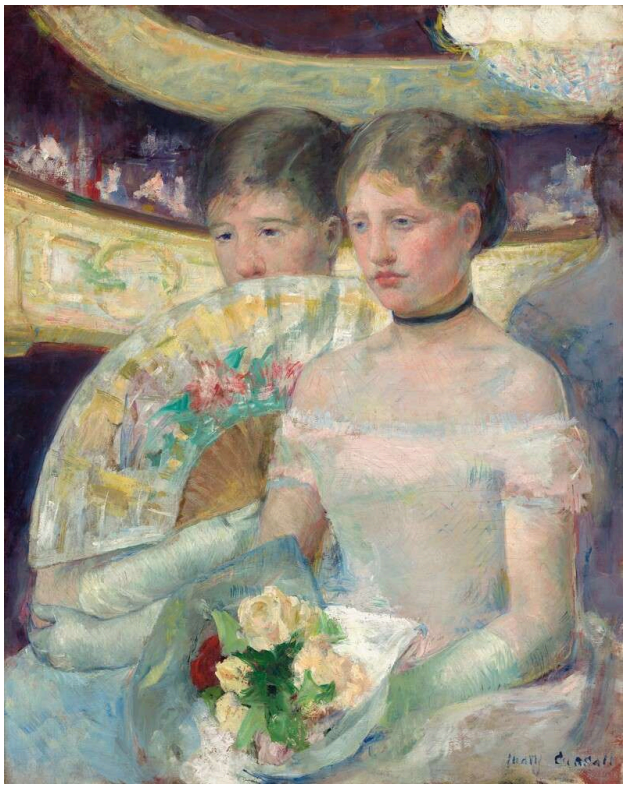
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1983.1.18

02 / 20

The Loge

Mary Cassatt

c. 1878-1880 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

The stage is absent. Instead, Cassatt gives the theatre's spectators the visibility usually reserved for performers. Flowers, bright dress and an open fan make attendance a form of public presentation. The fan partly conceals a face even as its spread attracts attention: an object that belongs to the display can also limit access to the person within it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.96

03 / 20

Woman with a Fan

Mary Cassatt

c. 1878/1879 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

The fan stretches across the sitter's lap, dividing the portrait into a face above and hands below. A mirror supplies an additional angle on her head and chair. More information does not produce a complete account of the person. Her direct gaze holds its own against the decorative folds and the doubled view behind her.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.95

04 / 20

The Cup of Tea

Mary Cassatt

c. 1880–1881 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Mary Cassatt; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Cup and saucer require the hands to perform different tasks. That small coordination determines the pose within the elaborate hat, gloves and pink dress. The raised cup holds the activity briefly short of drinking. Cassatt finds movement inside a formal social occasion, while the loose colour keeps its carefully observed manners from becoming a rigid diagram.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 22.16.17

05 / 20

Young Girl at a Window

Mary Cassatt

c. 1883-1884 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

The window offers depth, but the sitter's immediate attention belongs to the dog on her lap. Contact occupies the foreground while roofs and greenery recede outside. Neither direction cancels the other. The painting can hold a private, absorbed activity and an inhabited world beyond it without making the figure turn outward to explain their relationship.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2014.79.9

06 / 20

Children Playing on the Beach

Mary Cassatt

1884 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

Digging involves an awkward grip, bent arms and a body leaning toward its task. Cassatt brings those efforts close, leaving the sea as a narrow distance behind the children. The beach is not chiefly scenery for adults to admire. Buckets and spades give its smallest occupants something demanding to do, and the composition takes that demand seriously.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1970.17.19

07 / 20

Child in a Straw Hat

Mary Cassatt

c. 1886 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

With no elaborate setting to supply an anecdote, the joined hands and tilted hat become especially noticeable. The child's unsmiling face need not be translated into a fixed mood. Warm cheeks interrupt the subdued clothes and background; the uneven brim prevents the upright figure from becoming entirely symmetrical. A portrait can be particular without explaining its sitter.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1983.1.17

08 / 20

Girl Arranging Her Hair

Mary Cassatt

1886 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

The task generates the pose. One arm reaches back while the other gathers the hair forward, making a set of angles against the close red pattern. Nothing theatrical has to happen for the body to become complicated. The arrangement anticipates a recurring problem in Cassatt's washing and dressing scenes: how to make ordinary coordination clear.

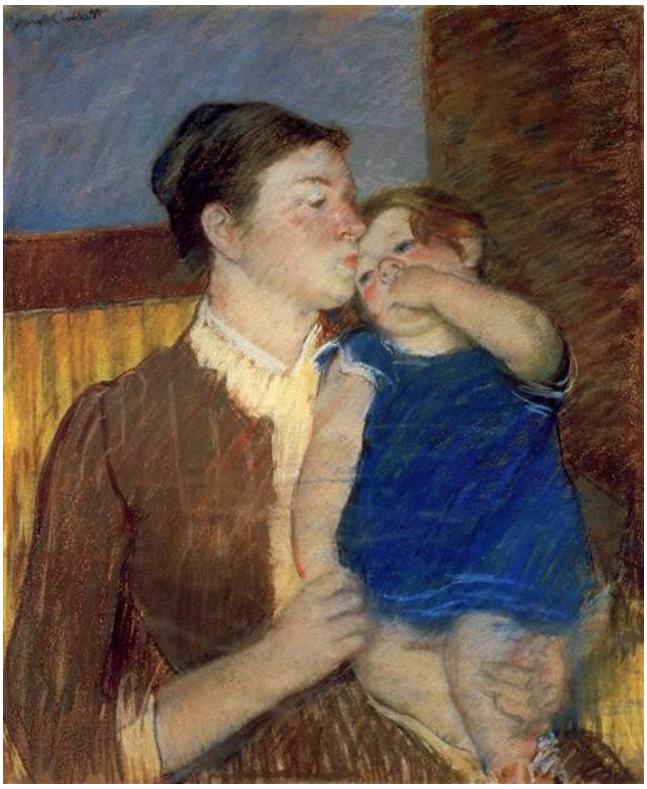
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.97

09 / 20

Mother's Goodnight Kiss

Mary Cassatt

1888 · Pastel on blue-gray wove paper (faded to tan), mounted on canvas, on a strainer · Art Institute of Chicago



Mary Cassatt; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

The child initiates contact, reaching upward and placing a hand against the adult's cheek. Support from below makes that reach possible. The broad pastel strokes of the garment remain visible around the more closely attended faces. Affection appears as an exchange of movements between bodies of different sizes, rather than as an expression placed on two matching faces.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1922.421

10 / 20

Afternoon Tea Party

Mary Cassatt

1890-1891 · color drypoint, softground etching, and aquatint on laid paper · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt; This file was donated to Wikimedia Commons as part of a project by the National Gallery of Art . Please see the Gallery's Open Access Policy . · CC0 1.0

The pale print leaves much of its paper exposed, asking a few curves and light colour areas to establish the meeting. The raised cup is enough to locate a pause in the conversation. This impression should not stand for every version: variations in inking can change the weight of the same design, so the sheet's accession number matters.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1943.3.2744

11 / 20

In the Omnibus

Mary Cassatt

1890-1891 · color drypoint, softground etching, and aquatint on laid paper · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt; This file was donated to Wikimedia Commons as part of a project by the National Gallery of Art . Please see the Gallery's Open Access Policy . · CC0 1.0

The bench brings the women close, but their attention goes in different directions. One looks away; the other attends to the baby. The compartment compresses them between a strip of window and the skirts filling the foreground. Public travel and childcare share this small space without merging into a single, harmonious group portrait.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.250

12 / 20

Maternal Caress

Mary Cassatt

1890-1891 · color drypoint, softground etching, and aquatint · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt; This file was donated to Wikimedia Commons as part of a project by the National Gallery of Art . Please see the Gallery's Open Access Policy . · CC0 1.0

The child wraps an arm around the woman's neck and presses toward her face. A continuous contour gathers the embrace into one shape, while the patterned dress preserves the distinction between their bodies. The adult's lap provides a broad base for an energetic movement above it. Cassatt makes closeness readable through pressure and support.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1946.21.87

13 / 20

The Coiffure

Mary Cassatt

1890-1891 · color drypoint, softground etching, and aquatint on laid paper · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt; This file was donated to Wikimedia Commons as part of a project by the National Gallery of Art . Please see the Gallery's Open Access Policy . · CC0 1.0

A view from behind might conceal the action, but the mirror returns the woman's face and bent shoulders. Her raised arms remain intelligible from both directions. With little shading to round the body, the line of the back becomes decisive. Striped upholstery and patterned wallpaper provide a deliberately busier setting around that restrained contour.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.257

14 / 20

The Fitting

Mary Cassatt

1890-1891 · color drypoint, softground etching, and aquatint on laid paper · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt; This file was donated to Wikimedia Commons as part of a project by the National Gallery of Art . Please see the Gallery's Open Access Policy . · CC0 1.0

The mirror doubles the standing customer, not the kneeling dressmaker. Display takes up the tall part of the composition; the labour that makes it possible stays close to the floor. The striped gown links the two positions, since its hem is both something to be seen and something requiring adjustment. Fashion appears with its work still attached.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1950.1.42

15 / 20

The Letter

Mary Cassatt

1890-1891 · color softground etching, drypoint and aquatint on laid paper · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt; This file was donated to Wikimedia Commons as part of a project by the National Gallery of Art . Please see the Gallery's Open Access Policy . · CC0 1.0

The writing has finished, but the letter is not yet ready to leave. Cassatt chooses the practical act of sealing the envelope, bringing the paper to the woman's mouth. Its pale surface interrupts the competing patterns of dress and wall. No invented romance is needed: the addressee and contents remain outside the information the image supplies.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.251

16 / 20

Woman Bathing

Mary Cassatt

1890-1891 · color drypoint, softground etching, and aquatint on laid paper · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt; This file was donated to Wikimedia Commons as part of a project by the National Gallery of Art . Please see the Gallery's Open Access Policy . · CC0 1.0

The back is almost unshaded, while the skirt's stripes bend around the hips. These are two different ways of describing a body, contour doing one job and pattern another. The mirror adds a second view as the woman leans toward the washstand. Her activity organises the room more decisively than an invitation to look at her does.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.253

17 / 20

The Boating Party

Mary Cassatt

1893/1894 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

The rower's dark back takes a large share of the foreground, preventing the mother and child from becoming the picture's only subject. The curved boat edge encloses all three, with water rising high behind them. Work and leisure face each other across the same confined space. Broad colour areas make that unequal distribution of bodies immediately apparent.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.94

18 / 20

The Child's Bath

Mary Cassatt

1893 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Mary Cassatt · CC0 1.0

Washing one foot requires the whole arrangement to cooperate. The adult supports the child on her lap while reaching toward the basin, and both heads incline toward the task. Seen from above, the striped dress and surrounding patterns might scatter attention. The circle of the basin and the linked limbs gather it back around the work of care.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1910.2

19 / 20

Breakfast in Bed

Mary Cassatt

1897 · oil , canvas · The Huntington



Mary Cassatt; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The adult turns toward the child, who looks elsewhere. Physical closeness does not make their attention identical. White pillows and tight framing remove most of the surrounding room, so that small difference in direction carries unusual weight. Cassatt allows the child's separate awareness to remain part of an affectionate scene rather than treating it as a failure of intimacy.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Woman with a Sunflower

Mary Cassatt

c. 1905 · oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt · NGA Open Access — public domain

The child examines a small mirror while a larger one repeats the pair behind them. Looking becomes an activity within the portrait as well as something the viewer does outside it. The sunflower's round centre echoes the handheld glass, but does not need to supply a secret meaning. Shape already connects the objects.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.98

Leave the figures some privacy

Compare a painting in which two people meet each other's attention with one in which they do not. Cassatt makes room for both. The selection spans several collections and includes prints whose impressions differ; use the object records to identify a particular sheet, and check current display information separately before visiting.

Further reading

Mary Cassatt, 1844–1926

Adelyn Dohme Breeskin · National Gallery of Art, 1970 · Free museum PDF

An exhibition catalogue with an introduction, object entries and reproductions. It provides a broad survey to set beside the narrower thread of everyday activity followed in this guide.

Mary Cassatt at Work

Jennifer A. Thompson and Laurel Garber · 2024 · Publisher page; purchase or library

The catalogue considers Cassatt as a professional artist and examines the labour shown in her pictures. Technical research and correspondence add to the questions raised here by The Fitting and the bathing scenes.

Artist resource · Museum research

Sources checked: 2026-10-12